



PROGRESS REPORT

Eswatini: progress report, August 2025 – August 2026

Edition of 2026-08-26 · 84 systems and instruments tracked

Of 84 systems and instruments on this place's ledger, 50 changed position between 2025-08-01 and 2026-08-26, 8 did not, 18 carry no stated baseline, and 8 are **Not held** at both ends.

SUMMARY OF THE PERIOD · GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS · WHERE THE RECORD IS THIN

Shape check, run before the comparison: 78 sources for this place in the window — 19 in the earlier half (2025-08 to 2026-01), 59 in the later (2026-02 to 2026-08). The earlier half of the window is thin: this is a shorter comparison wearing a longer label, and the movement below rests mostly on the later half.

Movement values. *Advanced* — a system entered service, a stage was completed or an instrument was made. *Stalled* — a stated target passed without delivery. *Regressed* — an instrument was withdrawn or neutralised, or a measured position worsened. *Closed* — the programme ended. *No change* — the position at both ends is the same. *Baseline not held* — the base carries no position at the start of the period, so no movement can be stated. A value may carry a qualifying clause after a comma, as in *Advanced, slipped*.

Summary of the period

The twelve months to August 2026 turned Eswatini's data-protection statute into a working institution and its digital programme into an approved loan. The authority went from [not operationalised in July 2025](#) to [investigating a government ministry in June 2026](#) and [drafting sectoral health-data guidelines in July](#). The [Digital Eswatini Project's financing was approved](#).

What did not move is the foundation. The [payment switch stood at phase one of three at both ends of the window](#), no national population register entered the record, and the [National Data Centre still discloses no capacity, tenant or uptime tier](#) while the state's dependence on it was formally named a concentration risk.

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
National Data Governance Policy	Being procured through a Smart Africa tender (2025-07)	Validated; targeted for completion before end-2026, with a standalone law or amendments to existing legislation undecided	ADVANCED

Legislation and regulation

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Cybersecurity, critical infrastructure, e-commerce and AI legislation	Did not exist	Announced as forthcoming; no bill text or tabling date on file	ADVANCED
Online Media Publishing Guidelines 2026	Did not exist	Complete on the ministry's account, introducing publisher registration and rules on accuracy, privacy, child safeguarding and the responsible use of AI; text and commencement date not public	ADVANCED

Data protection

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Advisory guidelines on processing personal health data	Did not exist	In validation; to be published as a regulatory instrument under the Data Protection Act	ADVANCED
Biometric gate passes in schools	Did not exist	Deployed and refused by some teachers and parents on consent and child-data grounds	ADVANCED
Data Protection Act applied to online naming and shaming	No application of the Act to personal online posting held	A social-media practice of publicly naming individuals over alleged private conduct is reported as exposing posters to a penalty of up to E100,000 under the Data Protection Act 2022	ADVANCED
Eswatini Data Protection Authority	Office not operationalised three years after the Act took effect (2025-07)	Operating: an awareness campaign, a registration deadline of 31 March 2026, one concluded complaint and one investigation into a ministry	ADVANCED
Home Affairs publication of unblurred national identity documents	Did not exist	Under investigation by the data protection authority	ADVANCED
United States bilateral health agreement and its data-sharing agreement	Not held	A health-funding memorandum with the United States worth more than 3.24 billion emalangeni, about US\$195 million, announced during a call by a State Department official on the prime minister under a bilateral global health strategy	ADVANCED
Data Protection Act 2022	In force, authority not operationalised	In force; fines to E5,000,000 or 2% of annual turnover	NO CHANGE
Restrictions on children's access to social media	Baseline not held	Under consideration only: two ministries stated to be working on online-content regulation in answer to a Senate question, with no bill, mechanism or age threshold named	BASELINE NOT HELD
Sector data-protection guidelines	Not held	Draft sector guidelines under the Data Protection Act 2022 validated at a week-long workshop, which also produced a proposed whistle-blower-protection framework; the regulator used it to name the financial sector as the leading source of personal-data breaches, through misdirected statements and invoices and cybersecurity incidents exposing customer records	BASELINE NOT HELD

Regional collaboration

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
SADC adequacy model for cross-border data transfers	In force	In force	NO CHANGE

Standards

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Division of the data-protection mandate	Not stated on the record	Executive holds policy, ESCCOM holds implementation, enforcement and oversight; no third institution named	ADVANCED

Public debate and participation in policymaking

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Public account of the Google memorandum	Not on the record	Established after a public contradiction between the prime minister and the Attorney-General	ADVANCED

The window's real movement is institutional. The Data Protection Act has been in force since 2022, but the [office to run it was recorded as not operationalised in July 2025](#). By February 2026 the authority was [running a compliance campaign with a 31 March registration deadline](#); by June it had [opened an investigation into the Ministry of Home Affairs for publishing unblurred national identity documents](#), a probable breach on which the ministry also missed the 72-hour notification duty; by July it was [drafting sectoral guidelines on personal health data](#) and had concluded one complaint against a practitioner.

Policy followed the same path from procurement to text. The National Data Governance Policy was [being tendered in July 2025](#), reached a [first national workshop in April 2026](#), and was [validated on 27 July 2026 for a 2027-2031 cycle](#) with its text still unpublished.

Two things were said on the record in the window that had not been before. The [Google memorandum was established as a cloud-services and e-government framework after a public contradiction between the prime minister and the Attorney-General](#), and the sponsoring ministry [stated that data-protection implementation and enforcement are ESCCOM's, not its own](#) – the clearest statement of the mandate the base holds.

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Global South Utilities discussions on data-centre power	Did not exist	In discussion; no capacity, price or timetable stated	ADVANCED

New investments

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Digital Eswatini Project	Under preparation	Approved: E648m for broadband and E450m for Government In Your Hand, with a 2027 rollout	ADVANCED
World Bank digital-transformation opportunity	Baseline not held	US\$165m, equivalent to E2.8bn, identified and unaddressed in the year-end statement	BASELINE NOT HELD

The window's financing question was settled at its end: the [Digital Eswatini Project's more than E1.06bn was approved on 19 July 2026](#), E648m for broadband and E450m for the citizen application. That approval sits against a [US\\$165m opportunity, equivalent to E2.8bn, that a January 2026 column noted had gone unmentioned in the prime minister's year-end statement](#). No domestic appropriation line was held at either end of the window.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Mbabane smart-city deployment	Did not exist	Under installation; no completion date published	ADVANCED
Minimum internet service standard	2 Mbps minimum	10 Mbps proposed; the 2 Mbps standard remains in force	ADVANCED
National fibre-optic backbone	47 Gbps international capacity	72 Gbps international capacity; rollout continuing	ADVANCED
Public-institution connectivity programme	Did not exist	859 schools, 134 health facilities and 38 tinkhundla centres to be connected	ADVANCED
Mobile coverage against mobile-internet use	About 95% 4G coverage against about 58% internet use	95% mobile coverage against 57% mobile-internet subscription (2026-07)	NO CHANGE
Statutory complaint adjudication by ESCCOM	In force	In force	NO CHANGE
Cost of data as a share of income per head	Baseline not held	3.47% of gross national income per head	BASELINE NOT HELD

Data Storage

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
National Data Centre	Operating; no capacity, tenant, uptime tier or utilisation disclosed	Operating and named a structural concentration risk; still no capacity, tenant, uptime tier or utilisation on file	NO CHANGE

Energy

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Power supply to the National Data Centre	Baseline not held	Still being sourced five years after the facility opened; no capacity, price or timetable stated	BASELINE NOT HELD

Cybersecurity

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
SADC regional cybersecurity framework	Did not exist	Approved regionally; no national implementing instrument on file	ADVANCED
Government services available online	Baseline not held	31 of 419 services online; 15 of 22 ministries run on 1 Mbps or less; 18 ICT professionals support the assessed estate	BASELINE NOT HELD
Ministry data backup and ICT maintenance	Baseline not held	9 of 21 ministries keep no regular backups, 11 have no ICT maintenance contract, and the finance ministry runs mainframe software past end of life	BASELINE NOT HELD
National cybersecurity awareness programme	Baseline not held	Run annually; no national cybersecurity strategy or CERT on file	BASELINE NOT HELD

Capacity moved and use did not follow. [International capacity rose from 47 to 72 Gbps](#) on the World Bank-supported rollout, above target; mobile coverage was about 95% at the window's opening and [95% at its close, against mobile-internet subscription of 57%](#). The regulator's response arrived in the window's last month: a [proposal to raise the minimum service standard from 2 Mbps to 10 Mbps](#), not yet in force.

Satellite went from a reseller channel to state infrastructure. A [Starlink Business reseller launched in July 2025](#); by April 2026 the government had [commissioned its own Starlink gateway to reduce dependence on cross-border fibre](#).

The state's own estate is where the window's most consequential finding sits, and it is the government's own. The [Digital Landscape Assessment endorsed on 21 May 2026](#) found nine of twenty-one ministries keeping no regular backups, eleven with no ICT maintenance contract, the finance ministry running mainframe software past end of life, only 31 of 419 services online, and near-universal dependence on one hosting provider named as a structural concentration risk. Nothing comparable existed at the window's opening, so the position did not worsen — it became visible.

DPI

Data Exchange

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Government system interoperability	Baseline not held	More than half of ministries lack meaningful interoperability or central-repository connectivity	BASELINE NOT HELD

Digital Identity and CRVS

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Digital identity	Conceptualised only	Planned under the Digital Eswatini Project; nothing issued	ADVANCED
National e-KYC registry	Did not exist	Under construction, with a SADC cross-border dimension; the FinTech Strategy targets 500,000 users by 2028	ADVANCED
National identity card	Production suspended over technical failures	Production resumed; the card does not meet the criteria for digital identification	ADVANCED

Digital Payments and Fintech

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Comparative benchmark of bank charges	Did not exist	Recommended, benchmarked against SACU and Common Monetary Area banks	ADVANCED
National FinTech Strategy 2025-2030	Did not exist	In force, targeting 500,000 e-KYC users and 80% interoperability by 2028	ADVANCED
Post offices as government payment points	Did not exist	35 post offices accepting government-service payments	ADVANCED
Eswatini Payment Switch	Fast Payments live with three of eight integrating participants	Fast Payments live; open banking and card, point-of-sale and ATM switching still to come	NO CHANGE
PAPSS accession	Not a participant	Not a participant; no accession date, target or application status stated	NO CHANGE
Bank transaction charges	Baseline not held	A withdrawal of E4,000 attracting E79 to E89 in fees (2026-07)	BASELINE NOT HELD
Cash share of person-to-business payments	Baseline not held	More than 90% still cash-based (2025-08)	BASELINE NOT HELD
Migration of Common Monetary Area low-value flows to TCIB	Baseline not held	Low-value transactions moving off domestic electronic-funds-transfer rails onto the regional scheme	BASELINE NOT HELD

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Mobile money platform migration to a cloud-native vendor platform	Did not exist	The dominant operator's mobile money platform moved off a legacy virtualised environment onto a cloud-native vendor fintech platform, the vendor reporting cuts of up to 86% in CPU processing and database load and up to 80% in API response times; the migration completed in Eswatini, Ghana, Rwanda and Uganda, with Cameroon under way and Benin, the Republic of the Congo and Zambia in discussion	BASELINE NOT HELD

Registries

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
National population register	Not held	Compulsory register of every birth, marriage and death since 1984; a paper-based statute, not shown to be digitised	ADVANCED, NEWLY DOCUMENTED
Proposed DNA requirement for birth certificates	Did not exist	Proposed; about E4,300 per test across about 29,400 births	ADVANCED, PROPOSAL ONLY

Sectoral management information systems

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Community health services digitisation	Paper-based	Digitised	ADVANCED
Umelusi, TruMD and Content Creator Hub platforms	Did not exist	In service	ADVANCED

Other GovTech and e-Gov

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Eswatini Revenue Service TaxPal	Did not exist	In service	ADVANCED
Google Cloud EMEA memorandum	Signed on or before January 2025, unacknowledged in public	Established as a cloud-services and e-government framework, not a monetisation deal; no value or term published	ADVANCED
Government In Your Hand citizen application	Launched May 2025, with a reporter able to locate public data on it six weeks later	In service, ahead of the digital identity and public-key infrastructure it was to rest on	ADVANCED
Auditor-General strategic plan 2026-2030	Not held	Launched with artificial intelligence and digital transformation named as the route to stronger public-sector accountability, urging more than 80 audit officers to adopt them, and developed with support from the INTOSAI Development Initiative and the African organisation of English-speaking supreme audit institutions	BASELINE NOT HELD
National e-Government Strategy	Baseline not held	Assessment endorsed; no strategy published	BASELINE NOT HELD

Payments changed on strategy and not on rails. The [switch's Fast Payments module](#) was live at both ends of the [window](#) and [phases two and three were not](#). What arrived was policy and measurement: the [National FinTech Strategy 2025-2030](#) launched in [December 2025](#) targeting 500,000 e-KYC users and 80% interoperability by 2028; the e-KYC registry itself began construction; and the [FinScope](#) survey that will replace an eight-year-old inclusion figure launched in [July 2026](#). The behaviour those instruments target is unmeasured since [more than 90% of person-to-business payments](#) were reported as cash in [August 2025](#).

The window's clearest regression is in identity, and it was mechanical. [Production of the national identity card was suspended in late September 2025 and resumed only on 22 February 2026](#), disrupting banking, employment and travel for months — on a card that [does not meet the criteria for digital identification](#) in the first place. Electronic IDs moved from conceptualised to [planned under the Digital Eswatini Project for 2027](#). No national population register entered the record at either end.

Service platforms multiplied. [Government In Your Hand and TaxPal launched in May 2025](#); thirty-five post offices opened as government payment points in September 2025; three sector platforms for agriculture, health and the creative economy launched with MTN in June 2026; and community health services moved from paper to digital records. The interoperability beneath them did not: [more than half of ministries lack meaningful interoperability or central-repository connectivity](#).

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Tinkhundla centre connectivity	Did not exist	38 centres targeted; none reported connected	ADVANCED

Rural digital data capture

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
USSD access to public services	Did not exist	Planned for the 2027 rollout	ADVANCED
Agricultural extension officer digital devices	Not held	40 tablets and 4 laptops, valued at E313,504, handed to agricultural extension officers on 10 August 2026 under an IFAD and Green Climate Fund-backed project, for real-time crop, livestock and weather reporting by officers working with smallholder farmers across all four regions	BASELINE NOT HELD

Technology

AI

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
ESCCOM guidance on AI and deepfakes in broadcasting	Did not exist	Issued as guidance; not an instrument with force	ADVANCED
Regional AI health partnership	Did not exist	Memorandum signed; no system, data-sharing terms or money named	ADVANCED
National 4IR Strategy	In force	In force, anchoring a stated human-centred approach	NO CHANGE

ICT Industry

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Letshego Eswatini digital bank	Did not exist	Provisional licence held; no launch date on file	ADVANCED

Innovation ecosystem

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Eswatini-Taiwan digital cooperation	Did not exist	On the agenda; no instrument, financing figure or implementing agency named	ADVANCED

Eswatini had no AI strategy at the window's opening and has none at its close. What it acquired instead is two instruments that regulate AI without being about it: [ESCCOM's deepfake and broadcasting guidance in November 2025](#) and the [Online Media Publishing Guidelines 2026](#), whose AI provisions are enforced through publisher registration.

The stated posture hardened over the window into a public position at [Geneva in July 2026](#): small and developing nations should not become mere consumers of technologies developed elsewhere.

The partnerships that carry the sector all sit with foreign parties. The [Google relationship went from a memorandum nobody would confirm to a publicly acknowledged framework with a national showing at the Google Cloud Summit Africa 2026](#), value and term still unpublished. A [UAE-delivered women's academy took its first 50](#), and [Taiwan and a regional health body added agreements with nothing costed](#).

Capacity

Literacy

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Published guidance on digital workplace transformation	Baseline not held	One published work on file; no national literacy programme or measurement	BASELINE NOT HELD

Training and skills

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
AI, robotics and cybersecurity training at innovation hubs	Did not exist	Announced; no start date, provider or cohort size given	ADVANCED
Digital Eswatini change agents	Did not exist	In training across ministries	ADVANCED
Macetjeni digital innovation hub	Did not exist	A second hub, in the Lubombo Region, backed by the development programme with the communications regulator and the small-enterprise development company, targeting young people, women and people with disabilities; no intake target, running cost or funding term is stated	ADVANCED
Digitally skilled citizens targeted	Baseline not held	300,000 targeted, in a population of about 1.2m	BASELINE NOT HELD

Inclusion

Access to services

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Account ownership	Below 50% a decade earlier	63% account ownership, led by mobile money	ADVANCED

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Innovation hubs	One hub, at Piggs Peak (2025)	Two hubs, the second opened at Macetjeni in the Lubombo region on 7 August 2026 to extend digital-skills and small-business support to a rural community, built by the small enterprise development company with the communications commission and UNDP under a youth empowerment programme	ADVANCED

Digital divides

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Community innovation hubs	One hub, at Pigg's Peak	Two hubs; a third planned for the Shiselweni Region	ADVANCED

Inclusion improved on ownership. Global Findex 2025, cited in August 2025, put account ownership at 63% against below 50% a decade earlier, led by mobile money. Price moved into view rather than down: the committee report of July 2026 is the first dated transaction price the base holds.

Capacity delivery began late in the window and small against the ambition. A target of 300,000 digitally skilled citizens was set in February 2026 in a population of about 1.2m; by August the country had two community innovation hubs and a third planned, cross-ministry change agents in training, and a first cohort of 50 in the UAE-delivered academy.

Data

National statistics

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
FinScope Consumer Survey	87% access rate recorded in 2018	2026 round in the field, covering access, usage and quality; no fieldwork dates, sample size or publication date given	ADVANCED
State of Communications Sector Study 2025/26	Did not exist	Under way; no publication date on file	ADVANCED

Use of satellite data

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Government Starlink satellite gateway	Did not exist	Commissioned	ADVANCED
Starlink Business reseller channel	Did not exist	Operating, with managed hardware, installation and support	ADVANCED

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
Google partnership with Eswatini	Signed on or before January 2025; workspace, AI, digital addressing and youth skills	Operating and publicly acknowledged; no value or term published	ADVANCED

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
US-Eswatini specimen sharing agreement	Did not exist	A ten-year agreement under which Eswatini shares specimens, samples, sequencing data and any other associated data on novel and emerging infectious diseases within seven days of a United States request, consents to those specimens and data being passed to up to ten non-US-Government United States entities, and accepts that failure to share could change or discontinue the assistance planned under the underlying memorandum of understanding of 11 December 2025. Either party may terminate on six months' notice, and termination by Eswatini does not affect use of anything already shared	ADVANCED

Gulf/UAE activities

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-26	MOVEMENT
She Powers Africa Digital Academy	Did not exist	First cohort of 50 women from government institutions; curriculum designed, staffed and certified abroad	ADVANCED

Where the record is thin

SYSTEM OR INSTRUMENT	WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT	LAST PROBED
Compute or high-performance computing capacity	A capacity disclosure for the National Data Centre - rack count, megawatts, uptime tier or utilisation - or a separate compute facility specification.	2026-08-09
Open government data portal	A national open-data portal, the published National Data Governance Policy text, or an access-to-information instrument.	2026-08-09
European Union digital cooperation with Eswatini	A named EU or European Investment Bank instrument, financing or programme covering Eswatini digital work.	2026-08-09
National AI strategy	A national AI strategy or statute, or a ministerial statement giving its drafting stage and expected adoption date.	2026-08-09
Chinese digital investment in Eswatini	Any Chinese financing, contract or memorandum covering Eswatini digital infrastructure.	2026-08-09
Indian digital cooperation with Eswatini	The India Exim Bank line-of-credit agreement or a programme document describing what it funds.	2026-08-09
Public research programme in digital or data science	A university research centre mandate, a public research programme, or published research output in digital or data science.	2026-08-09
Domestic budget appropriation for digital transformation	The estimates of expenditure or appropriation act showing lines for the ICT ministry, ESCCOM or the Royal Science and Technology Park.	2026-08-09
United States bilateral health agreement and its data-sharing agreement	The memorandum of understanding and the related data-sharing agreement themselves, a signature date, or an Eswatini government statement naming the instrument. The text is withheld rather than unpublished, and is in litigation in the United States District Court for the District of Columbia	not yet probed

Nine rows carry no position at either end, and they are the same nine that would have been empty a year ago. Nothing in the window filled a foundational gap: no population register on file, no data-centre capacity disclosure, no AI strategy, no domestic appropriation line, no open-data instrument. The window added systems, financing and an enforcing regulator, and left the layer beneath all three exactly where it was.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

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